

Cleaning and inspecting

Keeping your plants' leaves free of dust stops the pores getting blocked, thereby helping them breathe more easily. Cleaning also allows plants greater access to the light that they need for efficient photosynthesis. Clean plants regularly by supporting each leaf in your palm then wiping with a cloth or paper towel dampened with lukewarm water. Add a small squeeze of lemon to the water occasionally, to help remove residue build-up.



Keep it clean

Gently wiping leaves with a damp cloth to remove dust will help your houseplants breathe.

Also, keep a regular eye out for insects or pests lurking on the stems and foliage, remembering to check the undersides of leaves. Treat any pests using appropriate care from your local garden center and pull off any diseased or infected leaves.

Repotting

Repotting gives your houseplant room to grow and stay healthy. You should generally repot in spring, only when the plant's roots have outgrown the pot. Check the bottom of the pot to see whether roots are coming through, insert your finger into the soil to see whether it's solid with roots, or take the plant out of the pot to see whether the roots are circling around the inside. If the answer to these checks is yes, the plant is root-bound and needs to be repotted.



Maidenhair ferns like good humidity and indirect light (see pp.34–35)



Right at home

Place moisture-loving plants in a tray of wet pebbles to help create a humid environment.